WOLFE

BY DORIAN WOLFE

GUIDE FOR 50+

SCAM-PROOF DATING GUIDE

How romance scams work, how to check a profile, what to say, and what to do if you have been caught.

DORIAN WOLFE · CALM. DIRECT. REAL.

INSIDE

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Dorian Wolfe shares general communication advice for adults. It is not therapy and no result is guaranteed. Always respect other people's boundaries and consent.

INTRODUCTION

WHY THIS MATTERS

Online dating can be a good way to meet people. It is also where criminals look for lonely, trusting people. Anyone can be fooled. Scammers are professionals, and they are good at it.

The size of the problem	The FTC reported that people aged 60 and over lost about $2.4 billion to fraud in 2024. That covers all fraud types, and romance scams are one part of it.
Who is targeted	Men and women. A 2023 Pew report found that men and women aged 50+ were about equally likely to meet scams on dating sites.
The goal of this guide	Help you enjoy online dating while staying safe.

NOT YOUR FAULT

If you have been scammed, you are not stupid. Shame is what scammers rely on. Read chapter 8.

This guide focuses on the US. In other countries, use your local police and consumer protection agency.

CHAPTER 1

HOW A ROMANCE SCAM WORKS

1. Contact	A friendly message from an attractive profile.
2. Fast bond	Lots of attention. "I have never felt this way." Messages morning and night.
3. Move off the app	They ask you to switch to WhatsApp, Telegram or text, away from the app's protections.
4. A story	They are overseas, in the military, a widower, a business owner, a doctor.
5. The problem	A sudden emergency, a fee, a ticket, a business problem.
6. The ask	Money, gift cards, crypto or a wire transfer. Or an "investment" opportunity.
7. More asks	Once you pay, the requests continue. They may disappear, or threaten.

CHAPTER 2

12 RED FLAGS

- [ ] Perfect photos, or photos found elsewhere online.
- [ ] Wants to leave the dating app very quickly.
- [ ] Says "I love you" within days or weeks.
- [ ] Will not video call, or the camera "never works".
- [ ] Lives or works abroad, or is away on a ship, base or project.
- [ ] Story has gaps, or changes.
- [ ] Asks questions about your money, home or retirement.
- [ ] A sudden emergency needing money.
- [ ] Asks for gift cards, crypto or wire transfers.
- [ ] Pressures you to hurry or keep it secret.
- [ ] Suggests an investment or trading platform.
- [ ] Gets angry or sad when you hesitate.

THE RULE

One flag: slow down. Two or more: stop and talk to someone you trust.

CHAPTER 3

HOW TO CHECK A PROFILE

Reverse image search	Upload their photos to Google Lens or TinEye. If they appear under other names, it is a fake.
Search the name and details	Search their name, job, and phone number with the word "scam".
Check consistency	Do the age, job, location and story fit together?
Ask for a live video call	A real person will agree. Scammers make excuses.
Ask simple questions	About their town or workplace. Notice vague or copied answers.

REMEMBER

AI can fake photos and voices. A live video call helps but is not foolproof. Judge the whole pattern.

CHAPTER 4

MONEY RULES

- ✕ Never send money, gift cards, crypto or wire transfers to someone you have met online.
- ✕ Never share your bank details, card numbers, ID or one-time passcodes.
- ✕ Never "invest" with someone you met online.
- ✕ Never receive money or packages and forward them for someone. This can be used for money laundering.
- ✕ Never click links they send, or install apps they suggest.

SIMPLE TEST

If a person you have never met in person asks for money, the answer is no. There are no exceptions.

CHAPTER 5

INVESTMENT AND CRYPTO SCAMS

The FTC's data for older adults names **investment scams** as the category with the largest losses. In a typical version, a person you met online mentions a profitable trading app, shows fake gains, and encourages you to put in more.

- Be suspicious of any "guaranteed" or very high returns.
- Be suspicious if the person you met online suggests the platform.
- Check any firm with your country's financial regulator before investing.
- Talk to an independent adviser or trusted friend first.

CHAPTER 6

WHAT TO SAY

WHEN THEY ASK FOR MONEY

> I do not discuss money with someone I have not met.

WHEN THEY REFUSE A VIDEO CALL

> I would like to video call this week. If that is not possible, I will step back.

WHEN THEY PRESS YOU TO MOVE APPS

> I am happy to keep chatting here for now.

WHEN YOU WANT TO END IT

> I am going to stop here. Take care.

YOU DO NOT OWE AN EXPLANATION

You can stop replying and block them.

CHAPTER 7

MEETING IN PERSON SAFELY

- [ ] Video call first.
- [ ] Meet in a public place.
- [ ] Tell a friend who, where and when.
- [ ] Use your own transport.
- [ ] Keep your phone charged.
- [ ] Do not share your address or workplace early.
- [ ] Trust your instincts. Leave if something feels wrong.

CHAPTER 8

IF YOU HAVE SENT MONEY

1. Stop contact	Do not send more. Do not tell them you know.
2. Call your bank or card provider now	Ask whether the payment can be stopped or reversed.
3. Keep evidence	Messages, usernames, account numbers, receipts.
4. Report	US: reportfraud.ftc.gov and ic3.gov. UK: Action Fraud / Report Fraud. Canada: Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre. Australia: Scamwatch.
5. Beware "recovery" scams	Anyone who contacts you offering to get your money back for a fee is probably another scammer.
6. Tell someone	A friend, family member or helpline. You are not alone.
7. Look after yourself	Shame and anger are normal. Talk to someone. If you feel hopeless, call or text 988 in the US.

CHAPTER 9

PROTECT YOUR ACCOUNTS

- Use a different strong password for each account.
- Turn on two-factor authentication.
- Never share one-time codes.
- Do not click links from people you have not met.
- Keep your social media private, and limit what strangers can see.
- Review your bank and card statements regularly.

CHAPTER 10

TALK TO SOMEONE

Scammers try to isolate you: "Don't tell your family, they won't understand." That is a red flag in itself. Show your messages to a friend you trust, or ask someone to be your "second pair of eyes".

TRY THIS

Pick one person you would tell. Tell them you are dating online and ask them to check in.

IF IT FEELS HEAVIER THAN NERVES

If you feel hopeless, or think about harming yourself, please talk to someone now. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK, Samaritans: 116 123. Elsewhere, findahelpline.com lists local services.

A NOTE ON EVIDENCE

This guide uses general relationship and social-skills research plus common sense. Studies of men over 40 are limited, so treat everything here as practical guidance, not a guarantee. It is not therapy, medical advice, legal advice or financial advice.

BE CALM.

BE CURIOUS.

BE REAL.

— Dorian Wolfe